four and five months has led me to form a most favourable opinion of His Majesty's character,' he wrote.

> The repeated reverses which His Majesty had sustained in his efforts to recover his Kingdom have had the effect of inducing many to suppose either that his cause was unpopular, or that he was deficient in spirit or ability; but such persons make no allowances for the arduous circumstances under which those efforts were made. Few men would have attempted the enterprises in which His Majesty failed . . . The Shah is at least not deficient in energy or resolution. From my observation of his character, I should pronounce him to be a mild, humane, intelligent, just and firm man. His faults are those of pride and parsimony. The former defect appears to the Chiefs in a more glaring light from its contrast with the behaviour of the Barakzai usurpers, who in order to preserve their power were compelled to place themselves more on a level with their adherents.

Macnaghten said he had reason to hope that 'His Majesty will gradually assume a less condescending demeanour, or at all events that his subjects will become more reconciled to the distant formalities of their Sovereign'. As for his parsimony, 'it is certainly misplaced at the present crisis, though there is much to be urged in defence of it. His means are very limited, and the claims upon his liberality are very numerous.'[54]

Ten days later, on 8 May, just after the last troops of the rearguard of the Bombay column had finally limped into the camp outside the city, Macnaghten organised a grand durbar for Shuja. This was intended as a public declaration of the resumption of his rule and as an opportunity for the people of Kandahar to pledge their formal allegiance. A magnificently canopied throne was raised on a small platform of mud at the Id Gah outside the city walls. It looked on to the Camel's Back where the mud ruins of the old city of Kandahar lay scattered beneath the Forty Steps and the Cave of Babur – the exact site of the Shah's defeat five years earlier. Shuja was led from the Timurid arcades of the great palace in the citadel by Macnaghten, who had taken the opportunity to dress up for the first time in his new viceregal regalia: 'full court dress such as is usually worn by officials at her Majesty's levees in England', noted one officer.

> Sir Alexander Burnes followed in a plain suit, surrounded by the Afghan chiefs, with whom he appeared to be in close and friendly converse. The winning smile, and frank and courteous manner of the latter gentleman appeared to have gained for him a degree of consideration which no other European could boast of . . . Nothing could exceed the splendour of the costumes in which the chiefs were clad, their turbans and weapons being studded with diamonds and other precious stones, whilst the horses on which they were mounted were perfect specimens of beauty.[55]